

Karl Marx Hof

Location Vienna, Austria

Vienna's Karl Marx Hof is an example of social planning given solid form. It was built in 1927–1930 as part of a sustained drive by Vienna's socialist ruling council to house the city's dispossessed. The result was 1,382 apartments of 322–644 square ft (30–60 square m) that could house more than 5,000 people. Karl Marx Hof is the longest residential building in the world, at 3,600 ft (1,100 m) from end to end. Architecturally, it is ponderous, an aspect reinforced by its unrelieved ocher and yellow coloring. Its centerpiece—four towers flanked by balconies, topped by tall masts—resembles a row of ocean liners.

Moscow Metro

Location Moscow, Russia

The building of Moscow's metro system was always intended to be more than a demonstration of Soviet engineering prowess. The goal was to create what were, in effect, a series of opulent and overwhelming underground palaces. The first line was opened in May 1935; by 1938, a further two had followed. Glistening with mosaics and marble statues of Soviet heroes—soldiers, workers, and collective-farm laborers—they were unlike stations in any other metro system in the world. Ploschad Revolutsii station has 72 such statues flanking deep-red marble arches. The undulating, arched walls of Novoslobodskaya station contain 32 stained-glass panels in intricate brass frames. Perhaps the most spectacular of all is Komsomolskaya station, from whose yellow vaulted ceiling, highlighted with white stucco, hang vast chandeliers.

► THE YELLOW-AND-OCHE FACADE OF KARL MARX HOF

Villa Mairea

Location Noormarkku, Finland

In the late 1930s, Finnish architect Alvar Aalto introduced a new concept to architecture: Modernism

made organic. He encapsulated this in the Villa Mairea, built in 1938–1939. Aalto's clients were rich and encouraged him to experiment. The result was an L-shaped house that was plainly modern, with expansive rooms flowing together, but which also embraced traditional materials,

above all stone and wood. This, in part was an attempt to make the house an extension of the woods that surround it. The villa sought to be formal and informal, restrained and inventive, in a way rivaled only by Frank Lloyd Wright's architecture (see p.318).

